India to the Executive Board of UNESCO on which she stayed from 1960 to 1964.

In her work on Indira Gandhi, international relations professor Surjit Mansingh analyses how Indira's childhood and youth framed her views on foreign and domestic politics as well as on governance. Indira, according to Mansingh, was convinced that 'she embodied the will of the Indian people' or as the then president of the Congress Dev Kanta Barooah, in a fit of sycophancy, said, 'Indira is India and India is Indira.'[74] Just as Indira had a lonely 'insecure' childhood so India faced a global environment that was 'indifferent and often hostile.'[75] Asia and the world had been Nehru's focus and his scepticism of the superpowers had led him to maintain a healthy distance from both. Indira, on the other hand, chose the South Asian region as her focus, and suspicions of the intentions and policies of the superpowers, especially the United States, in India's immediate neighbourhood was coloured by her international outlook.

There were other differences between Nehru and Indira. Nehru's policies were shaped by his knowledge of history and sympathy towards socialism, whereas Indira did not have any ideological predispositions. Both pursued what they deemed to be India's national interest but their approach to the world was markedly different. Nehru's world view had a moralistic tinge because of the influence of Mahatma Gandhi and the strongly moral national struggle. Indira, on the other hand, one spoke the language of realpolitik and where she used moral slogans it was in her search for power and desire to boost India's status in the world. According to Dixit, Indira undertook a 'radical' change in India's foreign policy orientation by changing India 'from an idealistic player into a force to be reckoned with.'[76]

In a broadcast two days after becoming prime minister in January 1966, Indira asserted that the principles guiding India's foreign policy were based on 'national interest, honor and dignity.'[77] Thus, Nehru's policy of peace and friendship towards all countries would continue but India's security and